

REFLECTIVE ESSAY

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Whose Partition?

*Gender, Memory, and the Silenced Voices of 1947 on Film;
Written in response to the campus Partition film screening, 14–15 August 2025*

**SSC2252: Living With Conflict
Fall 2024**

Portfolio note

This reflective essay was written for Living With Conflict after a two-day Partition film screening held on the ULAB campus in August 2025, with talks by Professor Sayeed Ferdous and Khalid Hussain. It works through two questions the screening raised — how women experienced Partition differently, and whose memories the films preserve or silence — using the films alongside Veena Das, Urvashi Butalia, Ritu Menon and Kamla Bhasin, Ian Talbot, and Gyanendra Pandey. I have kept the personal voice of the original; the casualty figures for the Jallianwala Bagh massacre have been attributed to the official Hunter Commission record, with the historical dispute over the true toll noted.

Why a Partition screening felt new

A film screening on 1971 or on Sheikh Mujib would have been one event among many. A screening on the 1947 Partition was something I had never seen on our campus. Partition is not studied much in our academic setting, and the recent political shift seems to have opened a little space to engage with a chapter of our history we usually skip past. The two-day event in August 2025 felt, for that reason, genuinely new. The films mattered, but so did the speakers — Professor Sayeed Ferdous and Khalid Hussain — who brought lived experience and scholarship to bear and opened up a way of seeing 1947 that most of us had not been offered before.

Professor Ferdous made the case for why Partition studies matter: the event was one of the largest migrations in human history, displacing more than fifteen million people and killing perhaps two million in communal violence, and the questions it raised about identity, nationalism, and displacement have not gone away. He was careful about something I had not considered. Studying Partition is not a rival to our 1971 narrative; it is the ground beneath it. The two are complementary. Moving past the India-centred telling of Partition, he argued, makes room for the people that telling leaves out — ethnic minorities, and the Urdu-speaking community who hoped 1971 would bring them a homeland and instead found disappointment. Their version of the history, he said, was “put in a box and pushed away.”

That line stayed with me, because it named something about myself. I had never felt much for the Urdu-speaking community in Bangladesh. I had not thought about them at all. The screening made me see that this was not a gap in my feeling but a feature of the narrative I had inherited — their memory had been sidelined so completely that its absence was invisible to me. This is close to what Maurice Halbwachs meant in arguing that memory is collective and socially framed: we remember through the frameworks our group hands us, and what the group has no framework for, we simply do not recall (Halbwachs, 1992). Film, as an accessible way into those silenced frameworks, is what the rest of this essay is about.

Do women experience Partition differently?

The films screened — among them *Rajkahini*, *Meghe Dhaka Tara*, and *Garm Hava* — made one thing clear: women lived through Partition in ways that had little to do with how men did. They carried a disproportionate share of the violence and the displacement, and their agency was the first thing the moment took from them. Veena Das, Urvashi Butalia, and the pairing of Ritu Menon and Kamla Bhasin have each examined where gender and Partition violence meet, and the films read differently once you have read them.

Veena Das argues that Partition's violence was a kind of productive force that reshaped social relations, and that women's bodies in particular became the ground on which communal honour was fought over. Her central move is to show that this violence did not stay a single, contained event; it descended into the ordinary, lodging itself in the texture of daily life long after 1947 (Das, 2007). *Meghe Dhaka Tara* shows exactly that descent. Nita, a refugee from East Pakistan living in a Calcutta camp, gives up her health and her hopes to keep her family going, and dies of tuberculosis with the cry "I want to live." The tragedy is not a massacre. It is the slow conversion of a displaced woman into a household's shock absorber. Das's grim point is that the gendered legacy of Partition often reduced women's agency to silent endurance.

Urvashi Butalia documents the scale of the sexual violence, estimating that between 75,000 and 100,000 women were abducted and raped, and she is attentive to

how those experiences were then silenced — the honour killings and forced abortions in which a woman's will was overridden by communal command (Butalia, 1998). *Rajkahini* puts that resistance on screen. Begum Jaan and the eleven women of her brothel refuse to give up their home as the new border is drawn through it, dismissing the Congress and Muslim League men who come to move them. When a hired gang attacks, they take up rifles, and their final act — collective suicide in the burning brothel, echoing the legend of Rani Padmini — turns destruction into a last assertion of will. The film insists on the humanity of women the official story would not have bothered to name.

Menon and Bhasin fill in the rest of the picture, detailing mass suicides, mutilations, and rapes, but also the moments where women found a way back to agency through social work or economic survival after Partition (Menon & Bhasin, 1998). *Garm Hava* works in that register of slow psychological violence. Amina, abandoned again and again by fiancés who migrate to Pakistan, loses even the right to choose a marriage and finally takes her own life; the elderly mother's fatal stroke on being evicted from the ancestral home is displacement felt as bodily collapse. Both deaths fit Das's sense of violence as an ongoing process rather than a single blow. Taken together, the films show women targeted as symbols of honour, displaced out of the domestic roles that had defined them, and finding agency, when they found it at all, in resilience or open resistance. They are an argument for reading Partition through gender, because that is the only way the silenced half of it comes back into view.

Whose memory survives, and whose is lost?

The wider set of films — *Jinnah*, *Viceroy's House*, *Gandhi*, *Train to Pakistan*, *Toba Tek Singh*, *Garm Hava*, *Meghe Dhaka Tara*, *Rajkahini* — mostly preserve the memory of political elites, the urban middle class, and particular communal narratives. What they underrepresent is the subaltern: rural peasants, lower castes, indigenous communities, and a great deal of women's private trauma. This is the selective memory that Ian Talbot and Gyanendra Pandey both warn about.

The voices I thought of first were the ones Khalid Hussain described — people who could not say out loud who they were or what language they spoke, who had to shed

their identities and take on new ones simply to survive and to get an education. They cut off their own relatives, because being seen with them could expose the identity they were hiding behind. They never even entered the camps where their neighbours and kin suffered, which severed them from their own past a second time. No film I saw was about them.

Ian Talbot shows how official accounts fix on political leaders and big cities and let rural and lower-class lives fall out of frame (Talbot, 2006). You can see it in *Jinnah and Viceroy's House*, which build Partition around Muhammad Ali Jinnah and Lord Mountbatten and stage it as a negotiation among powerful men, with the grassroots suffering kept somewhere off-screen. *Gandhi* preserves Gandhi's leadership and lets the ordinary chaos of the violence sit at the edges of the frame — not absent exactly, but always arranged around the great man. Gyanendra Pandey makes the sharper point that national histories tend to suppress subaltern memory altogether, defaulting to clean communal binaries rather than the messier intersections of caste and class (Pandey, 2001). *Train to Pakistan* catches a Punjab village's communal tension well, but largely leaves out the Dalit experience of being hit twice over, by caste and by communal violence at once. *Garm Hava* speaks for a middle-class Muslim family and not for poorer or rural Muslims; *Toba Tek Singh* turns the asylum into a brilliant symbol of national dislocation but does not record the specific traumas of the ethnic minorities or women inside such places; *Meghe Dhaka Tara* keeps Nita's refugee story and loses the non-bhadralok and multi-regional refugees around her; *Rajkahini* centres sex workers' resistance and still leaves transgender and lower-caste stories at the margin.

What the films did to me

The human dimensions — grief, confusion, hope, resilience — are what stayed. In *Toba Tek Singh*, the protagonist's death in no-man's-land is the confusion of identity loss made literal. It hurts to watch him keep asking where Toba Tek Singh now belongs and keep being misled, and then, once he understands that the place itself is in an undecidable state, refuse to move at all and die on the line between two countries. The supposedly mad men in the asylum turn out to be the sane ones; the real madness sits in

the boardroom, or in Viceroy's House, where men divide a map without a thought for the people whose roots are being cut by the pencil.

Some of it I could barely sit through. The way General Reginald Dyer ordered the firing at Jallianwala Bagh is the part that makes my skin crawl. With the calm of a man ordering coffee, he positioned around fifty soldiers along the edge of an enclosed public garden in Amritsar and had them open fire on an unarmed Baisakhi crowd — no warning, no order to disperse, not a word. They fired coldly and without haste, emptying their magazines into a crowd that had not threatened them, aiming toward the few narrow exits people were trying to escape through. By the official Hunter Commission count, roughly 1,650 rounds were fired in about ten minutes, leaving 379 dead and well over a thousand wounded. Even those figures are contested: the Indian National Congress inquiry put the dead above a thousand, and a later study reached beyond fifteen hundred, because the colonial administration never attempted a full count and families removed bodies overnight (Talbot, 2006). The exact number will never be known, which is its own kind of erasure — ordinary people reduced to the arithmetic of bullets and casualties, their voices gone. It made me sad in a plain way: ordinary people paid, and the people who profited sat far from the garden.

The grief in *Garm Hava* — Amina's suicide, the mother's stroke — makes displacement's emotional cost impossible to keep at a distance. Rajkahini's women, making their defiant stand and choosing death together, reading a puthi of some great figure as the fire takes them, was the scene that broke me; someone in class asked whether it was based on a true story, and the honest answer is that there were stories worse than this one, which stopped me cold for a moment. Nita's sacrifices in *Meghe Dhaka Tara* and her last plea to live connect to a resilience in my own heritage that usually goes unsung. This is what the films do that a textbook cannot: they turn the event back into people, and in doing so they make the case for studying Partition at all — to recover the voices that were boxed up and pushed away, the Urdu-speaking community, the ethnic minorities, the religious minorities, and to make the next division a little harder to order so calmly.

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